

Title MD Deepfake: The Russian MFA claims West will be meddling in Moldovan elections 10/10/2025

Summary

- On August 1, Maria Zakharova, the spokeswoman of the Russian MFA, accused Moldova of accepting Western interference in the electoral process, referring to a fake video in which Angelica Caraman, the Head of the Central Electoral Commission, allegedly endorsed French interference.
- In the video Ms. Caraman allegedly stated that interference from states such as France should not be considered “interference” in the electoral process, since Moldova is in the process of joining the EU.
- The case likely violates Moldovan election law and EU’s Digital Service Act (DSA) obligations.
- The video aims to undermine the credibility of the electoral results if the pro-European forces’ results prevail. The strategy revolves around creating a pretext for reacting to the victory of a pro-European party by framing it as rigged with the support of European partners.
- Recommendations include a comprehensive communication strategy to sustain Moldova’s European choice by taking into account the fact that platforms often do just partial takedowns without systemic dismantling of the influence campaign overall.

Incident

On August 1, Maria Zakharova, the spokeswoman of the Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MFA) [accused](#) Moldova of accepting Western interference in the electoral process, referring to a fake video in which Angelica Caraman, the Head of the Central Electoral Commission (CEC), [allegedly endorsed](#) French interference. Ms. Caraman allegedly stated that interference from states such as France should not be considered “interference” in the electoral process, since Moldova is in the process of joining the EU. Zakharova’s post on Telegram garnered over 353 thousand views. One day before, on 31 July, Moldovan CEC [claimed](#) the video content to be faked using AI generation technology in the official press statement.

While the origin of the video is unknown, it [spread](#) mostly on accounts affiliated with pro-Russian influence actors on Telegram. ISSP identified 282 content items amplifying the false narrative that originated from the deepfake from July 30 to August 18. Over a half (145) were X posts including reposts and quote posts. The rest were 81 articles on Russian media outlets and content aggregators, 48 posts on VKontakte (VK), the Russian analogue for Facebook, seven posts on Telegram, one YouTube video.

The potential reach of all content items identified is 800,282,388 readers while the estimated number of actual views is 102,9320. Social media accounts that amplified the falsehood garnered 782,686 estimated views on social media platforms except X where such a metric is not available. Zakharova’s Telegram post alone garnered 353,000 views. The total reach of media and content aggregators was 795,890,967 but the estimated number of actual views was just 246,634. Despite the high numbers of estimated views, analysis of direct engagement metrics (likes, replies/comments, shares) across social media and conventional media outlets including content aggregators demonstrates an extremely low level of interaction. There were just 732 total engagements on X and 2,452 total engagements on VK, while engagement with media and content aggregator articles was only 76 in total. This suggests low genuine interest in the subject and lack of active public discussion.

Systemic Violation Assessment

The incident may have a long-term negative effect on pro-Russian, anti-European, or even neutral segments of the Moldovan population, due to proactive construction of alleged Moldovan authority’s logic regarding what should be considered foreign interference and counterarguments against both the results of pro-European forces and pro-European rhetoric in Moldova.

Manipulation lies in both content (false facts, impersonation) and behaviour (amplification of often identical content) with some FIMI context due to the direct vocalisation of the case by the Russian MFA.

The case likely violates Moldovan election law and EU’s Digital Service Act (DSA) obligations. It also likely violates impersonation, manipulated media, and election integrity rules outlined in Terms of Service agreements by respective platforms

Narrative

Meta narrative: Moldovan elections are illegitimate due to Western interference:

Sub-narratives:

Western countries are hypocritical when blaming Russia in foreign interference;

Electoral outcomes are not the result of Moldovan citizens' will, but of Western interference:

- a) Election results were approved in Brussels before votes were counted;
- b) The West is manipulating Moldova's democratic processes.

Impact

Reach: 676,320 estimated views over 282 content items. The total engagement with the content was 3,257.

Outcome: N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective 1: [T0135: Undermine](#): the campaign directly targets the credibility of CEC by using a quote from fabricated video that presents the institution as hypocritical and subservient to foreign interests, fulfilling the goal of undermining trust in the electoral process itself.

Objective 2: [T0135.004: Smear](#): The deliberate use of the quote from the fabricated video attributed to CEC Chair Angelica Caraman constitutes a direct personal smear, portraying her as corrupt or a "Western slave," aiming to discredit her individual authority and integrity.

[T0087.001: Develop AI-Generated Videos \(Deepfakes\)](#) - The entire campaign is anchored on a synthetic or "deepfake" video and associated quote attributed to Caraman, demonstrating the use of fabricated media as primary evidence to seed the narrative.

[T0022.001: Amplify existing narratives](#) - The use of the "Western interference" narrative and the phrase "Это другое" (This is different/Double Standards) explicitly taps into and amplifies long-standing conspiracy narratives about Western "external governance" and "color revolutions" in post-Soviet states.

[T0110: Formal diplomatic channels](#): The immediate citation and ironic commentary by the Russian MFA spokesperson, Maria Zakharova, successfully provides the fake content with pseudo-official legitimacy and guarantees massive amplification across state-controlled media (e.g., RIA Novosti, VZGLYAD.RU), turning the low-quality fabrication into a state-endorsed narrative.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: N/A

Recommendations: To launch a proactive communication strategy by CEC and Moldovan government to reaffirm electoral integrity; To frame the incident as an attack on Moldova's sovereignty, not just an attack on Caraman personally; Collaborate with communication specialists within official institutions to inform fact-checkers and civil society about the case, and jointly produce detailed materials that equip all stakeholders to pre-bunk common electoral interference narratives ahead of elections; Document this case as a violation of Moldovan electoral law, GDPR, laws on information, and impersonation provisions under Terms of Service, to create a precedent for legal action.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
N/A	Russia.	Upon Request	Marianna Prysiashniuk, ISSP; Kostyantyn Ryzhkov, ISSP; Nika Aleksejeva, DFRLab	Websites, content aggregators, Twitter, VK, Telegram, YouTube	Medium Certainty